

[Return to Search](#)

Original Page: 306

Culture (OWC): [San \(FX10\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1969-1971

Coverage Date: 1921-1971

Place Coverage: Dobe Area, Northwest Botswana

Section Title(S): Chapter 14 Further Losses

Sometimes, however, directness is unavoidable. At such times the good-natured tease—although not innocuous, still a fairly safe option—may be employed. Between two people who have a joking relationship, the following scene might transpire. A young woman walks into the village with a bright strand of beads around her neck. An older woman sees them and jokes, “Oh, those beads are already mine! Your past stinginess is going to be turned around today!” The younger woman returns the tease in the same spirit, “Look who’s talking about stinginess! I would die of ugliness before my neck would be adorned with beads given by you!” The exchange develops into an insult match, in which the women level sexual and other verbal barbs at each other. Amusing as it is, the underlying criticisms do not go unnoticed. In a desire to maintain friendly relations, the younger woman gives her antagonist the beads (or something else) later that day. After a few weeks, the gift is reciprocated with one of comparable appeal. The problems between the women are thus resolved for a time.

578
Ingroup Antagonisms

626
Social Control

If the two women are in-laws and have a respect relationship, the situation will be somewhat different. The older woman might sit in her hut and talk loudly to herself: “Does youth need anything to make it beautiful? How is it no one helps this old woman’s heart feel young again?” It is likely that her target (or someone close to her) would hear this lament through the thin grass walls of the hut. Or the older woman might sing her criticisms for all to hear, accompanying herself on a thumb piano or [307](#) pluriarc, while sitting alone in the darkness of the night. In either case, a generous exchange of gifts would probably result.

534
Musical Instruments

578
Ingroup Antagonisms

626
Social Control

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries:  hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs:  hraf-support@yale.edu



[Terms and Conditions](#) · [Accessibility](#) · [Cookie Policy](#)